



ADVANCED PATHWAY · 15 WEEKS

Theories of the State

A Sample 15-Week Pathway · Designed for Lisa, age 17, Oxford PPE

PROGRAMME OVERVIEW

Lisa is a 17-year-old student applying to Oxford's Politics, Philosophy, and Economics (PPE) undergraduate course. Drawing on ideas from philosophy, political theory, political science, and political economy, this pathway explores what the state is, why it exists, and how it relates to its citizens. Lisa's tutor will guide her through reading accessible extracts of Hobbes, Rousseau, and other theorists of the state. These works will form the basis of their discussions on sovereignty, rights, democracy, colonialism, globalisation, surveillance, and other themes.

Lisa will practise writing critically and persuasively through weekly assignments and will receive comprehensive feedback from her tutor on this work. These writing projects will culminate in a final 3,000-word essay on a topic of Lisa's choice. The assigned readings were chosen for their importance and accessibility, and amount to an average of 30 pages per session.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Content Overview

- Understanding how major thinkers define the state, its purposes, and its relationship to citizens
- Comparing ideas of the nation, state, and citizenship
- Investigating the state and its citizens' rights and responsibilities
- Exploring how colonialism, war, and capitalism shape modern states and state-building
- Critical feminist and postcolonial theories of the state
- Understanding liberty, democracy, and (digital) authoritarianism
- Dissecting identity, belonging, and nationalism

Skills

- Developing opinions based on informed, open-minded, and critical reflection
- Persuasively conveying arguments in speech and writing



- Weighing up competing evidence and ideas across primary sources, secondary commentaries, and real-world case studies
- Producing a 3,000-word well-argued and rigorously researched final essay

POSSIBLE FINAL PROJECT IDEAS

- A comparative essay evaluating two or more thinkers' views on the state's origins
- Evaluating the successes and limitations of one post-conflict state-building case study (e.g. Iraq after 2003, Iran after 1979, the Federal Republic of Germany after 1949, etc.)
- Comparing two models of the welfare state (e.g. Scandinavian model versus US model), discussing policies, and applying theoretical views on the state's obligation to citizens
- Devising a 21st-century social contract, including new terms for state–citizen relations in the digital age

WEEKLY PATHWAY

Week 1 What Is the State?

Readings and Materials

- Britannica “Nation-State” article – <https://www.britannica.com/topic/nation-state>
- Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy entry on “The State”
- Excerpts from Max Weber, Politics as a Vocation (short summary version from BBC In Our Time)

Discussion

- What do we mean when we say “the state”?
- How is a state different from a nation or government?
- Why do humans form political communities?
- What makes a state legitimate?
- What is sovereignty?

Exercise

- Distinguish between states, governments, and regimes with specific examples. Why do political scientists need these distinctions? (800 words)

Weeks 2–3 The State and the Social Contract

Readings and Materials

- John Locke, *Second Treatise on Government*, Chapters 2–3
- Jean-Jacques Rousseau, *The Social Contract*, Book I, Chapters 1–3 (Maurice Cranston translation)
- Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy on Thomas Hobbes' "Moral and Political Philosophy"

Discussion

- How do Hobbes, Locke, and Rousseau differ in their views on human nature?
- How useful is the social contract as an idea to understand citizen–state relations?
- Can children born into a society be said to have “consented” to its social contract? If not, does this undermine consent-based theories of political obligation?
- Can we devise social contract–centric justifications for COVID-19 pandemic lockdowns?

Exercise

- Compare Hobbes's and Locke's conceptions of the state of nature. What different assumptions about human nature underlie their theories? How do these assumptions lead to different conclusions about the legitimate scope of state power? (800 words)

Weeks 4–5 Power and Inequality: Marxist Thought

Readings and Materials

- Extracts from Karl Marx, *The Communist Manifesto*
- Extracts from George Orwell, “The Lion and the Unicorn: Socialism and the English Genius”

Discussion

- Why did Marx think the state serves the ruling class?
- If the state is “the executive committee of the bourgeoisie,” what does that mean in practical terms? Who or what is “the bourgeoisie” in today's globalised economy?
- Can a capitalist state ever act against capitalist interests (environmental regulation, wealth redistribution, labour protections)? If so, does this refute Marx's theory of the state?
- Marx argues that the state will “wither away” under communism. Is a stateless society possible in complex modern economies? What functions would remain?

Exercise

- Evaluate Marx's theory of the state as an instrument of class domination. Does this theory adequately explain welfare states, labour protections, or progressive taxation? How might Marxists respond to these apparent counter-examples? (800 words)

Week 6 Authority and Bureaucracy: Max Weber and Modern Government

Readings and Materials

- Extracts from Max Weber, "Bureaucracy" in *Economy and Society*
- Case study: civil service reform in modern British democracy

Discussion

- Weber saw bureaucratisation as an "iron cage" that restricts human freedom. Are there alternatives to bureaucracy for organising complex modern states? Or is bureaucracy unavoidable?
- Weber distinguishes authority (legitimate power) from coercion (illegitimate power). Can this distinction be maintained in practice? Who decides what counts as legitimate?
- Does bureaucracy serve efficiency and rationality, as Weber suggested, or does it primarily serve to shield elites from accountability?

Exercise

- Is the professionalisation of politics (career politicians, political consultants) an example of bureaucratisation? If so, is this good or bad for democracy? (800 words)

Weeks 7–8 State-Building and Post-Conflict Politics

Readings and Materials

- Extracts from Charles Tilly, "War Making and State Making as Organised Crime"
- Extracts from Frantz Fanon, *The Wretched of the Earth*, Chapter 1
- Case studies: post-conflict state-building after the 1994 Rwandan genocide or after the 2003 Iraq War

Discussion

- Why is violence central to the birth of many states?
- What challenges do post-colonial or post-conflict governments face?



- How do new states develop legitimacy in the eyes of their citizens after war or occupation?
- What are the problems with external intervention in the state-building process?

Exercise

- Evaluate competing strategies for post-conflict justice: retributive justice (trials), restorative justice (truth commissions), or amnesty. Which approach best serves state-building objectives? Use at least two cases. (800 words)

Week 9 Liberalism, Democracy, and Freedom

Readings and Materials

- Extracts from John Stuart Mill, On Liberty
- Extracts from Robert Dahl, "On Democracy"

Discussion

- How do elections and participation bolster the state's legitimacy in citizens' eyes?
- What are the limits of liberal tolerance? For instance, should liberal states tolerate illiberal groups (religious fundamentalists, fascists, etc.)?
- Should democracies restrict speech that undermines democracy itself (election disinformation, anti-democratic organising)?
- Are democracies always "better states" than authoritarian ones?

Exercise

- Using a case study (for instance, COVID-19 pandemic lockdowns, counter-terrorist surveillance measures, restrictions on radical right protesting rights, etc.), evaluate the trade-off between liberty and security in modern states. (800 words)

Week 10 The Welfare State and Economic Justice

Readings and Materials

- Extracts from John Maynard Keynes, The End of Laissez-Faire
- Milton Friedman lecture, "The Fallacy of the Welfare State"

Discussion

- What are the main tensions between Keynes's and Friedman's ideas?
- What obligations do states have toward citizens' well-being? Should the state provide healthcare, education, and other goods to its citizens?

- Do citizens have obligations to contribute (through work or taxes) in exchange for welfare benefits? Or are social rights unconditional?
- Drawing on Keynes, Friedman, and other thinkers discussed throughout the pathway, consider arguments for and against Universal Basic Income (UBI).

Exercise

- Compare the United States' healthcare system to the British National Health Service (NHS) as two opposing models of state welfare provision. Drawing on ideas studied so far throughout the pathway (citizenship rights, obligations, the state's role, etc.), make the case for one of these two healthcare systems. (800 words)

Week 11 Feminist and Critical Theories of the State

Readings and Materials

- Extracts from Carole Pateman, *The Sexual Contract*
- Extracts from Catharine A. MacKinnon, *Toward a Feminist Theory of the State*

Discussion

- How does MacKinnon argue that gender affects our experience of the state?
- According to Pateman, how were women excluded from the "original contract" that founds liberal modernity?
- Is political representation sufficient for gender justice, or does justice require transforming social and economic structures? What can states do about the latter?
- What would a "feminist state" look like?

Exercise

- Analyse MacKinnon's claim that "the state is male." What does she mean by this? Are you persuaded by this theory? Give examples of policies or state structures in any context of your choice to illustrate your answer. (800 words)

Week 12 Nation, Identity, and Belonging

Readings and Materials

- Extracts from Benedict Anderson, *Imagined Communities*
- Extracts from Partha Chatterjee, "Whose Imagined Community?"

Discussion

- What are the differences between civic, ethnic, and cultural conceptions of nationhood?
- What turns a population into a "nation"?

- How do symbols, language, and memory sustain national identity?
- Can nations exist without states – or states without nations?

Exercise

- Analyse the relationship between nationalism and democracy. Does national identity strengthen democracy (by creating solidarity) or weaken it (by excluding minorities)? Use empirical examples. (800 words)

Week 13 Globalisation and the Erosion of Sovereignty

Readings and Materials

- Extracts from Saskia Sassen, *Losing Control? Sovereignty in an Age of Globalization*
- TED Talk: David Held, “Global Governance... into the Future”

Discussion

- How does globalisation challenge the traditional state?
- What happens to democracy when decisions cross borders?
- Can international institutions replace state sovereignty?
- Who governs the global economy?

Exercise

- What would a ‘post-national’ world look like? In other words, a future world in which globalisation triumphs over nation-states as the organising principle of the world order. Evaluate the benefits and challenges that this would present. (800 words)

Week 14 Technology, Surveillance, and the Digital State

Readings and Materials

- Extracts from Glenn Greenwald, *No Place to Hide: Edward Snowden, the NSA, and the U.S. Surveillance State*
- Extracts from Shoshana Zuboff, *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism*

Discussion

- How do states use technology to manage or monitor citizens?
- How do states enlist the services of tech companies to surveil their citizens?
- Where should the line between safety and privacy be drawn?

- Should data rights be treated as human rights?

Exercise

- Assess competing approaches to data governance: market-based (US), rights-based (EU), or state-controlled (China). Which best balances innovation, privacy, and security? Defend your answer. (800 words)

Week 15 Conclusion

Discussion

- What were the key takeaways from this pathway?
- What ideas were most interesting, challenging, and provocative, and why?
- Which theories of the state did you find most compelling?
- Concluding reflections on why states exist, what states owe their citizens, and vice versa.
- Brainstorm ideas for the final 3,000-word project.